

First overview of governing equations

Lou van der Grinten

October 6, 2026

1 A note on notations

1.1 Material derivative

The following equations are all equivalent, which can be shown algebraically.

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{d}{dt} &= \frac{\partial}{\partial t} + u \frac{\partial}{\partial x} + v \frac{\partial}{\partial y} + w \frac{\partial}{\partial z} \\ &= \frac{\partial}{\partial t} + \mathbf{u} \cdot \nabla \\ &= \frac{\partial}{\partial t} + \mathbf{u} \cdot \text{div}()\end{aligned}$$

1.2 Tensors

$$\tau_{ij} \frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} = \boldsymbol{\tau} : \nabla \mathbf{u}$$

where

$$\nabla \mathbf{u} = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{\partial u}{\partial x} & \frac{\partial u}{\partial y} & \frac{\partial u}{\partial z} \\ \frac{\partial v}{\partial x} & \frac{\partial v}{\partial y} & \frac{\partial v}{\partial z} \\ \frac{\partial w}{\partial x} & \frac{\partial w}{\partial y} & \frac{\partial w}{\partial z} \end{pmatrix}$$

The $:$ is called the double contraction operator or the matrix inner product. It contracts two tensors into a scalar. Since τ is the symmetric stress tensor,

2 Starting equations (partial differential equations)

2.1 Energy equation

2.1.1 CRB

CRB: `cube11`

$$\rho C_v \frac{dT}{dt} + p \left(\frac{\partial u}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial v}{\partial y} + \frac{\partial w}{\partial z} \right) = k_T \nabla^2 T \quad (1)$$

I refer to `scto01` for the conversion into the constant-pressure heat capacity variant of this equation.

2.1.2 Jarvis & McKenzie, 1980

`jamc80` `jamc80`:

$$\rho C_p \left(\frac{\partial T}{\partial t} - \frac{\alpha T}{\rho C_p} \frac{\partial P}{\partial t} + \mathbf{u} \cdot [\nabla T - (\nabla T)_s] \right) = \nabla \cdot (K \nabla T) + H + \tau_{ij} \frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} \quad (2)$$

2.1.3 Gassmüller et al., 2020

Gassmüller: **gada20**

$$\rho C_p \left(\frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + \mathbf{u} \cdot \nabla T \right) - \nabla \cdot (k \nabla T) = \rho H + \tau : \dot{\varepsilon} + \alpha T (\mathbf{u} \cdot \nabla p) + Q_L \quad (3)$$

2.1.4 Schubert et al., 2001

scto01 presents three thermmal energy equations:

The general form of the energy equation (6.9.1) is:

$$\rho T \frac{Ds}{Dt} = \tau_{ij} \frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_j} \left(k \frac{\partial T}{\partial x_j} \right) + \rho H \quad (4)$$

For an incompressible Newtonian fluid (eq. 6.9.13 + 6.9.14):

$$\rho C_v \frac{DT}{Dt} = \frac{\partial}{\partial x_i} + \frac{\mu}{2} \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} \right)^2 + \rho H \quad (5)$$

with $\frac{\mu}{2} \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} \right)^2$ the viscous dissipation function.

In terms of C_p instead of C_v (for a compressible fluid) (eq. 6.9.16):

$$\rho C_p \left(\frac{DT}{Dt} - \left(\frac{\partial T}{\partial p} \right)_s \frac{Dp}{Dt} \right) = \frac{\partial}{\partial x_i} + \frac{\mu}{2} \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} \right)^2 + \rho H \quad (6)$$

with (eq. 6.9.15, 6.9.17):

$$\begin{aligned} \left(\frac{\partial T}{\partial p} \right)_s &= \frac{\alpha T}{\rho C_p} \\ \left(\frac{DT}{Dt} \right)_s &= \left(\frac{\partial T}{\partial p} \right)_s \frac{Dp}{Dt} = \frac{\alpha T}{\rho C_p} \frac{Dp}{Dt} \end{aligned}$$

2.2 Momentum equation

2.2.1 CRB

CRB: **cube11** per component

$$x : \rho \left(\frac{du}{dt} + f_* w - f v \right) = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \tau^{xx}}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \tau^{xy}}{\partial y} + \frac{\partial \tau^{xz}}{\partial z} \quad (7a)$$

$$y : \rho \left(\frac{dv}{dt} + f u \right) = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial y} + \frac{\tau^{xy}}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \tau^{yy}}{\partial y} + \frac{\partial \tau^{yz}}{\partial z} \quad (7b)$$

$$z : \rho \left(\frac{dw}{dt} - f_* u \right) = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial z} - \rho g + \frac{\tau^{xz}}{\partial x} + \frac{\tau^{yz}}{\partial y} + \frac{\partial \tau^{zz}}{\partial z} \quad (7c)$$

2.2.2 Jarvis & McKenzie, 1980

jamc80, eq. 4 **jamc80**:

$$\rho \left(\frac{\partial \mathbf{u}}{\partial t} + \mathbf{u} \cdot \nabla \mathbf{u} \right) = -\nabla P + \rho \mathbf{g} + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_j} \tau_{ij} \quad (8)$$

2.2.3 Gassmüller et al., 2020

Gassmüller **gada20**:

$$-\nabla \cdot \tau + \nabla p = \rho \mathbf{g} \quad (9)$$

2.2.4 Schubert et al. 2001

$$\rho \frac{du_i}{dt} = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial x_i} + \frac{\partial \tau_{ij}}{\partial x_j} + \rho g_i \quad (10)$$

In 2D, the momentum equation components are:

$$\rho \left(\frac{\partial u_x}{\partial t} + u_x \frac{\partial u_x}{\partial x} + u_y \frac{\partial u_x}{\partial y} \right) = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \tau_{xx}}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \tau_{xy}}{\partial y}, \quad (11)$$

$$\rho \left(\frac{\partial u_y}{\partial t} + u_x \frac{\partial u_y}{\partial x} + u_y \frac{\partial u_y}{\partial y} \right) = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial y} + \frac{\partial \tau_{xy}}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \tau_{yy}}{\partial y} + \rho g. \quad (12)$$

Note that the assumption is made that gravity acts in the positive y-direction. Section 6.14?

2.3 Mass equation (continuity equation) (trivial)

jame80, eq. 3 jame80:

$$\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial t} + \nabla \cdot (\rho \mathbf{u}) = 0 \quad (13)$$

CRB cube11:

$$\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial}{\partial x}(\rho u) + \frac{\partial}{\partial y}(\rho v) + \frac{\partial}{\partial z}(\rho w) = 0 \quad (14)$$

Gassmüller gada20:

$$\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial t} + \nabla \cdot (\rho \mathbf{u}) = 0 \quad (15)$$

schubert et al. (2001) scto01

$$\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_1}(\rho u_i) = \frac{1}{\rho} \frac{D\rho}{Dt} + \frac{\partial u_1}{\partial x_1} = 0 \quad (16)$$

where $\frac{D}{Dt}$ represents the material derivative (??). For incompressible flow, $\frac{D\rho}{Dt} = 0$, so eq ?? reduces to:

$$\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_i} = \nabla \cdot \mathbf{u} = 0 \quad (17)$$

2.4 Starting equations (constitutive equations)

2.5 Initial and boundary conditions

3 Appendix 1: tables of constants and reference/scaling values used

4 scto01 basic equations

This document/section has a different approach to structure the derivation of the ALA: this is a summary of the derivation of the ALA done by **scto01**. **red text means assumptions/approximations were made toward the ALA.**

Table 1: Constants used by **scto01**

Constant	Value	Name
k_b	0	Bulk viscosity
α		thermal expansivity
χ_T		isothermal compressibility
c_v		specific heat at constant volume
c_p		specific heat at constant pressure
χ_a		adiabatic compressibility
k		thermal conductivity
H		rate of internal heat production per unit mass
K_a		adiabatic bulk modulus
K_T		isothermal bulk modulus

Table 2: Reference values used by **scto01**

Symbol	Value	Description
ΔT		Characteristic temperature difference driving thermal convection
χ_{T_r}		Representative isothermal compressibility
α_r		Representative thermal expansivity
u_r	$\frac{k_r}{\rho_r c_{p_r} b}$	Velocity scale
μ_r	10^{21} Pa s	Representative viscosity
χ_a		Adiabatic compressibility
b		Depth of convecting region
p_r	$\frac{\mu_r u_r}{b}$	Scale for dynamic pressure variations
k_r	$4 \text{ W m}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$	Reference value thermal conductivity
c_{p_r}	$1 \text{ kJ kg}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$	Reference specific heat at constant pressure

4.1 Mass equation/continuity equation/conservation of mass

$$\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_i}(\rho u_i) = \frac{1}{\rho} \frac{D\rho}{Dt} + \frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_i} = 0 \quad (18)$$

where $\frac{D}{Dt}$ represents the material derivative (??). For incompressible flow, $\frac{D\rho}{Dt} = 0$, so eq ?? reduces to:

$$\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_i} = \nabla \cdot \mathbf{u} = 0 \quad (19)$$

For the special case of an incompressible fluid, $\frac{D\rho}{Dt} = 0$, so equation ?? reduces to

$$\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_i} = 0 \quad (20)$$

4.2 Momentum equations/conservation of momentum

Starting governing equation (6.4.1):

$$\rho \frac{Du_i}{Dt} = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial x_i} + \frac{\partial \tau_{ij}}{\partial x_j} + \rho g_i \quad (21)$$

Table 3: Dimensionless parameters and their values for the Earth's mantle

Parameter	Definition	Value	Description
Pr	$\frac{\mu_r c_{p_r}}{k_r}$	2.5×10^{23}	Prandtl number
M ²	$\frac{k_r^2 \chi_{T_r}}{\rho_r c_{p_r}^2 b^2}$	10^{-33}	Mach number (squared)
ϵ	$\alpha_r \Delta T_r$		Fractional density change due to temperature variations

we assume gravity g to be the only body force. The coriolis force is negligibly small in the Earth's mantle, and the centrifugal force due to the Earth's rotation is included in the gravity term.

In 2D, the momentum equation components are:

$$\rho \left(\frac{\partial u_x}{\partial t} + u_x \frac{\partial u_x}{\partial x} + u_y \frac{\partial u_x}{\partial y} \right) = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \tau_{xx}}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \tau_{xy}}{\partial y}, \quad (22)$$

$$\rho \left(\frac{\partial u_y}{\partial t} + u_x \frac{\partial u_y}{\partial x} + u_y \frac{\partial u_y}{\partial y} \right) = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial y} + \frac{\partial \tau_{xy}}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \tau_{yy}}{\partial y} + \rho g. \quad (23)$$

Note that the assumption is made that gravity acts in the positive y-direction. Section 6.14?ext

4.3 Navier-Stokes equation

The local strain rate tensor e_{ij} is given by:

$$e_{ij} = \frac{1}{2} \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} \right) \quad (24)$$

For a Newtonian, isotropic fluid, the relation between the deviatoric(!) stress tensor and the strain rate tensor is

$$\tau_{ij} = 2\mu e_{ij} + \lambda e_{kk} \delta_{ij} \quad (25)$$

Defining the bulk viscosity k_B :

$$\frac{\tau_{ii}}{3} = e_{ii} \left(\lambda + \frac{2}{3} \mu \right) = k_B e_{ii} \quad (26)$$

The combination of equations ??, ?? and ?? gives

$$\tau_{ij} = \mu \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} \right) + \left(k_B - \frac{2}{3} \mu \right) \frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} \delta_{ij} \quad (27)$$

and substitution of eq. ?? into eq. ?? gives

$$\rho \frac{Du_i}{Dt} = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial x_i} + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_j} \left[\mu \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} \right) + \left(k_B - \frac{2}{3} \mu \right) \frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} \delta_{ij} \right] + \rho g_i \quad (28)$$

For many fluids, k_B is taken to be zero (**Stokes assumption**), so eq. ?? becomes

$$\tau_{ij} = \mu \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} - \frac{2}{3} \frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} \delta_{ij} \right) \quad (29)$$

and eq. ?? becomes the Navier-Stokes equation:

$$\rho \frac{Du_i}{Dt} = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial x_i} + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_j} \left[\mu \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} - \frac{2}{3} \frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} \delta_{ij} \right) \right] + \rho g_i \quad (30)$$

for incompressible flow, equation ?? tells us $\frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} = 0$, and together with a constant dynamic viscosity μ so eq. ?? reduces to:

$$\rho \frac{Du_i}{Dt} = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial x_i} + \mu \frac{\partial^2 u_i}{\partial x_j^2} + \rho g_i \quad (31)$$

This equation represents a balance between inertial forces $\left(\frac{Du_i}{Dt}\right)$, pressure forces $\left(\frac{\partial p}{\partial x_i}\right)$, viscous forces $\left(\mu \frac{\partial^2 u_i}{\partial x_j^2}\right)$ and the body force due to gravity (ρg_i)

4.4 Thermal energy equations/conservation of energy

scto01 presents various different formulations of the energy equation.

The general form of the energy equation (6.9.1) is:

$$\rho T \frac{Ds}{Dt} = \tau_{ij} \frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_j} \left(k \frac{\partial T}{\partial x_j} \right) + \rho H \quad (32)$$

The terms on the right side of ?? are, respectively, volumetric heat production rates due to viscous dissipation (internal friction), thermal conduction, and internal heat generation (radiogenic?). Where it is assumed that Fourier's law of heat conduction for an isotropic medium is applicable:

$$q_i = -k \frac{\partial T}{\partial x_i} \quad (33)$$

Where q_i is the heat flux vector. Additionally, the viscous dissipation term can be written as the dissipation function:

$$\Phi = \tau_{ij} \frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} \quad (34)$$

Inserting the definition of our deviatoric stress tensor with $k_B = 0$ (eq. ??), this becomes

$$\Phi = 2\mu \left\{ \frac{1}{2} \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} \right) - \frac{1}{3} \left(\frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} \right) \delta_{ij} \right\}^2 \quad (35)$$

For an incompressible and Newtonian fluid ($\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_i} = 0$), the dissipation function reduces to

$$\Phi = \frac{\mu}{2} \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} \right)^2 \quad (36)$$

With various thermodynamic relationships:

$$\alpha = \frac{1}{v} \left(\frac{\partial v}{\partial T} \right)_p \quad (37)$$

$$c_p = T \left(\frac{\partial s}{\partial T} \right)_p \quad (38)$$

$$\left(\frac{\partial s}{\partial p} \right)_T = - \left(\frac{\partial v}{\partial T} \right)_p \quad (39)$$

It can be shown that

$$\frac{Ds}{Dt} = \frac{c_p}{T} \frac{DT}{Dt} - \frac{\alpha}{\rho} \frac{Dp}{Dt} \quad (40)$$

Plugging ?? into ?? gives

$$\begin{aligned} \rho c_p \frac{DT}{Dt} - \alpha T \frac{Dp}{Dt} &= \frac{\partial}{\partial x_i} \left(k \frac{\partial T}{\partial x_i} \right) + \Phi + \rho H \\ \rho c_p \left(\frac{DT}{Dt} - \frac{\alpha T}{\rho c_p} \frac{Dp}{Dt} \right) &= \frac{\partial}{\partial x_i} \left(k \frac{\partial T}{\partial x_i} \right) + \Phi + \rho H \end{aligned} \quad (41)$$

5 Approximate equations

In this section, Schubert derives the approximate forms of the equations of conservation of energy and momentum appropriate to mantle convection.

5.1 Equation of state (density ρ)

From now on, density ρ is considered a function of temperature T and pressure p only, neglecting the density changes associated with mineral phase transitions and changes in chemical composition.

Most of the density change in the mantle is due to hydrostatic compression. The mantle density increases by approximately 65% between the surface and the core-mantle boundary. This is Schubert's justification for assuming a linearized equation of state for mantle density:

$$\begin{aligned}\rho &= \bar{\rho}(\bar{T}, \bar{p}) + \rho' \\ \rho &= \bar{\rho}(\bar{T}, \bar{p}) + \left(\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial p}\right)_T p' + \left(\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial T}\right)_p T' \\ \rho &= \bar{\rho}(\bar{T}, \bar{p}) + \bar{\rho}\chi_T p' - \bar{\alpha}\rho T'\end{aligned}\tag{42}$$

with

$$\begin{aligned}T &= \bar{T} + T' \\ p &= \bar{p} + p'\end{aligned}\tag{43}$$

Where the overbar ($\bar{\rho}$) refers to a reference state and the primes (ρ') departures from it. The reference state is assumed motionless and steady:

- motionless: $\bar{u}_i = 0$
- steady: $\frac{\partial \bar{u}_i}{\partial t} = 0$
- motionless and steady: $\frac{D\bar{u}_i}{Dt} = 0$
- $\tau_{ij} = \mu \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} - \frac{2}{3} \frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} \delta_{ij} \right) = 0$ (??)

This reduces the momentum equation (??, ??) to its static form:

$$0 = -\frac{\partial \bar{p}}{\partial x_i} + \bar{\rho}g_i\tag{44}$$

Integrating equation ?? results in the hydrostatic equation. Further needed for the calculation of the reference state is the equation for the adiabatic temperature gradient (since the reference state temperature is assumed adiabatic)

$$\left(\frac{\partial T}{\partial x_i}\right)_s = \frac{\alpha T g_i}{c_p}\tag{45}$$

And a specification of the reference state equation of state $\bar{\rho} = \bar{\rho}(\bar{T}, \bar{p})$.

5.2 Nondimensionalization

Now, the linearized equation of state (??) will be nondimensionalized with scaling factors consisting of representative/characteristic values presented in table ??. With these, dimensionless variables (denoted with an asterisk *) are introduced by dividing the dimensional variables with their characteristic counterpart. Rewriting the **linearized equation of state** (??) in terms of these nondimensional variables gives:

$$\frac{\rho^*}{\bar{\rho}^*} = 1 + \bar{\chi}_T^* p' M^2 P r - \bar{\alpha}^* T' \epsilon\tag{46}$$

where

$$M^2 = \frac{k_r^2 \chi_{T_r}}{\rho_r c_p^2 b^2}, \quad P r = \frac{\mu_r c_{p_r}}{k_r}, \quad \epsilon = \alpha_r \Delta T_r\tag{47}$$

which are the Mach number (squared, measuring the influence of compressibility), Prandtl number (ratio of momentum diffusivity to thermal diffusivity, or, equivalently the ratio between advection and conduction) and the fractional density change due to temperature variations, respectively. I refer to table ?? for an overview of all dimensionless parameters discussed in this document. Plugging in the values from table ?? gives $Pr \approx 2.5 \times 10^{23}$, which is considered practically infinite, and $M^2 \approx 10^{-33}$ and consequently $M^2 Pr \approx 2 \times 10^{-10} \ll 1$. If $\epsilon \ll 1$ as well, $\frac{\rho^*}{\bar{\rho}} \approx 1$ and density perturbations due to mantle convection are small compared to the reference hydrostatic density of the mantle.

The dimensionless form of the **conservation of mass equation** (eq. ??) can be obtained in the same manner:

$$\begin{aligned} & \bar{\rho}^* \bar{\chi}_T^* M^2 Pr \frac{\partial p'^*}{\partial t^*} - \bar{\alpha}^* \bar{\rho}^* \epsilon \frac{\partial T'^*}{\partial t^*} \\ & + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_i^*} \left[\left\{ \bar{\rho}^* + \bar{\rho}^* \bar{\chi}_T^* p'^* M^2 Pr - \bar{\rho}^* \bar{\alpha}^* \epsilon T'^* \right\} u_i^* \right] = 0 \end{aligned} \quad (48)$$

In the limit of $\epsilon \rightarrow 0$ and $M^2 Pr \rightarrow 0$, eq. ?? reduces to

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial x_i^*} (\bar{\rho}^* u_i^*) = 0 \quad (49)$$

Which is known as the **anelastic conservation of mass equation** or the **liquid anelastic approximation** (??). The absence of the $\frac{\partial \rho'}{\partial t}$ term eliminates seismic waves from the set of equations governing mantle convection. This makes sense physically, since seismic activity and mantle convection occur on very different time scales. If, additionally, $\bar{\rho}$ is considered constant with depth, eq. ?? reduces to the incompressible continuity equation:

$$\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_i} = 0 \quad (50)$$

This approximation is called the **Boussinesq approximation**. For this approximation to be appropriate, the change in $\bar{\rho}$ with depth has to be investigated. Using the adiabatic compressibility

$$\chi_a = \frac{1}{\rho} \left(\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial p} \right)_s \quad (51)$$

and the hydrostatic equation

$$\frac{\partial \bar{\rho}}{\partial x_i} = \bar{\rho} \bar{g}_i \quad (52)$$

gives the density gradient

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial \bar{\rho}}{\partial x_i} &= \left(\frac{\partial \bar{\rho}}{\partial p} \right)_s \frac{\partial p}{\partial x_i} = \bar{\rho} \bar{\chi}_a \frac{\partial P}{\partial x_i} \\ &= \bar{\rho}^2 \chi_a \bar{g}_i \end{aligned} \quad (53)$$

The local density scale height is defined as

$$\bar{h}_d := \left\{ \frac{1}{\bar{\rho}} \frac{\partial}{\partial} \middle| \bar{\rho} x_i \right\} \Big|_{-1} \quad \text{program@epst01}$$

6 Appendix 1: tables of constants and reference/scaling values used

Table 4: Constants used by **scto01**

Constant	Value	Name
k_b	0	Bulk viscosity
α		thermal expansivity
χ_T		isothermal compressibility
c_v		specific heat at constant volume
c_p		specific heat at constant pressure
χ_a		adiabatic compressibility
k		thermal conductivity
H		rate of internal heat production per unit mass
K_a		adiabatic bulk modulus
K_T		isothermal bulk modulus

Table 5: Reference values used by **scto01**

Symbol	Value	Description
ΔT_r		Characteristic temperature difference driving thermal convection
χ_{T_r}		Representative isothermal compressibility
α_r		Representative thermal expansivity
u_r	$\frac{k_r}{\rho_r c_{p_r} b}$	Velocity scale (follows from assuming $Pe = 1$)
μ_r	10^{21} Pa s	Representative viscosity
b		Depth of convecting region
p_r	$\frac{\mu_r u_r}{b}$	Scale for dynamic pressure variations
k_r	$4 \text{ W m}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$	Reference value thermal conductivity
c_{p_r}	$1 \text{ kJ kg}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$	Reference specific heat at constant pressure
t_r	$\frac{b}{u_r} = \frac{\rho_r c_{p_r} b^2}{k}$	reference timescale

Table 6: Dimensionless parameters and their values for the Earth's mantle

Parameter	Definition	Value	Description
Pr	$\frac{\mu_r c_{p_r}}{k_r}$	2.5×10^{23}	Prandtl number
M^2	$\frac{k_r^2 \chi_{T_r}}{\rho_r c_{p_r}^2 b^2}$	10^{-33}	Mach number (squared)
ϵ	$\alpha_r \Delta T_r$		Fractional density change due to temperature variations